

UTEP's Kruta Strikes Oil In 'E.P. 16'

By PETE CICCARELLI

When Los Angeles Dodger southpaw Dennis James was toiling for the Texas League ballclub in El Paso two seasons ago he wore No. 16. "There are X-number of victories in each uniform," James once said jokingly. "When I wear this shirt out I'll go to another number."

James left El Paso before the jersey did and now that the bright orange "16" with "El Paso" on the front belongs to the University of Texas at El Paso, righthander Mike Kruta is picking up James' leftovers.

Overcoming spurts of wildness in the early innings yesterday Kruta hurled UTEP to a 10-4 triumph over New Mexico Highlands University and a sweep of a doubleheader. The Miners won the first game 6-5 when pinchrunner David Patt outraced a throw to the plate on Bob Downing's seventh-inning groundball.

THE MINERS host defending Big 8 baseball champion Oklahoma at noon tomorrow in Dudley Field. Righthander Dan Modlinski (1-0) is expected to draw the starting nod from skipper Andy Cohen.

Kruta and old No. 16 needed some help late yesterday after the Arlington, Tex. native squandered an early 3-0 lead. The necessary aid came in the fifth when the Miners turned "Sudden Death Dudley" into Cape Canaveral, launching homeruns by Mark Miller and Joe Pennies to break a 3-all affair into a 7-3 contest. A trio of orange scores floated home in the sixth to give Kruta added insurance.

"He threw real well," Cohen said of the scrappy 5-9, 175-pound righty. "He just needs to get a little meaner out there and he'll be fine."

TWO DOWNING homers in the opener brought UTEP back from a 4-0 deficit and lead to the day's sweep. The double wins gave the Miners a 3-1 series advantage over Highlands and lifted their overall mark to 5-3 on the year.

Oh yes! As for Kruta and his attire. In 1972 James led all minor league baseball in earned run average, strikeouts and fewest hits allowed per innings pitched.

Mike Kruta may have struck oil!

FIRST GAME

NMHU		220	000	1-5-7-1
UTEP		013	010	1-6-9-2

Bob FROIO and Tim Chubb. David Jannusch, Larry RICHARDSON (6) and Jim Brundage. W—Richardson (1-0) L—Froio (0-1).

HR: Utep, Bob Downing 2 (4).